Opening a salon in Alberta is straightforward — if you know exactly which permits to chase, and in what order. The problem is that nobody gives you the full picture in one place. The City of Calgary tells you about their business licence. Alberta Health Services tells you about their notification. The provincial government talks about trade certificates. Nothing connects the dots.

This guide does. Below is the complete list of every **salon licence in Alberta** you will need in 2026, with real current fees from the City of Calgary, the City of Edmonton, and Alberta Health Services, plus a realistic timeline and a printable checklist you can take to city hall.

Short version: **expect 6 weeks from first application to licensed-and-open day**, and budget around **$350 to $600 in total licence fees** for a small nail or beauty salon before you factor in build-out permits or signage. Hair salons have one additional requirement — a Journeyperson Certificate in Hairstylist for anyone cutting hair — because hairstyling is a compulsory certified trade in Alberta.

Quick overview: the 8 salon licences in Alberta

Here is every licence, permit, and registration a salon owner in Alberta may need in 2026. Some apply to every salon; others only apply in specific cases.

REQUIRED FOR ALL SALONS

1. Municipal Business Licence (Personal Service)

Issued by the City of Calgary or City of Edmonton. Calgary: **$285 new / $200 renewal**. Edmonton (Tier 3): **$265 new / $239 renewal**.

REQUIRED FOR ALL SALONS

2. AHS Personal Services Notification

Free, mandatory. Submitted online to Alberta Health Services before you open. Not a paid permit — a notification under the *Personal Services Regulation*.

REQUIRED IF YOU USE A BUSINESS NAME

3. Trade Name Registration

$60 government fee (plus registry agent service fee). Required any time you operate under a name other than your exact legal name. Renew every 5 years.

HAIR SALONS ONLY

4. Hairstylist Journeyperson Certificate

Compulsory trade in Alberta. Anyone cutting or styling hair for paying clients must hold this certificate or be a registered apprentice supervised by one.

IF REVENUE > $30K / YEAR

5. GST Number (CRA)

Free to register. Mandatory once your small business revenue exceeds $30,000 in any four consecutive calendar quarters.

IF YOU HAVE EMPLOYEES

6. WCB (Workers' Compensation) Account

Free to register. Mandatory if you have any employees. Premium rates are calculated annually as a percentage of payroll based on your industry classification.

IF DOING RENOVATIONS OR NEW BUILD

7. Development & Building Permits

City-issued, fees vary widely by project scope. Required if you are changing the use of the space, altering plumbing or electrical, or doing significant build-out.

IF YOU HAVE EXTERIOR SIGNAGE

8. Sign Permit

Separate permit required for most permanent exterior signs in both Calgary and Edmonton. Fees depend on sign size and type.

How to register a salon in Alberta: step-by-step process

The eight licences and permits above are the *what*. This section is the *when* — the order in which to tackle them, and the dependencies between steps, so you do not get blocked waiting on a permit that could not start until something else was in place.

This sequence assumes you are opening a new salon in Calgary or Edmonton. Some steps can run in parallel, but the numbered order is the safest sequence for a first-time owner.

1. **Verify zoning for your target location.** Before you sign any lease, confirm the address is zoned to allow a Personal Service Business. This is the single most common mistake first-time owners make. See our Calgary salon zoning guide for how to check.
2. **Choose your legal structure.** Sole proprietorship, Alberta corporation, or partnership. If you plan to borrow money or hire staff, an Alberta corporation is usually the right choice for liability protection and credibility with lenders.
3. **Register your trade name or incorporate.** Done at an Alberta Corporate Registry agent. A trade name is about $60 and processes same day. Incorporation is $450+ and takes 1-3 days. See trade name registration below for details.
4. **Register for GST with CRA.** Required if you expect more than $30,000 in annual revenue (essentially every salon). Free through CRA My Business Account. See GST and WCB below.
5. **Register with WCB Alberta.** Mandatory if you will have any employees (including yourself, if incorporated and paid through payroll). Apply online at wcb.ab.ca.
6. **Sign your commercial lease.** Only once zoning is verified. Negotiate a tenant improvement allowance and, if possible, a contingency clause that lets you exit if development permits are refused.
7. **Apply for your municipal business licence.** Calgary's Personal Service licence or Edmonton's Tier 3 licence. This triggers a fire inspection. Allow 5-15 business days after inspection passes. See municipal licensing below.
8. **Submit your AHS Personal Services Notification.** Required before you start offering services. Free and typically instant. See AHS notification below.

9. **Apply for development, building, and occupancy permits if needed.** Required if you are changing the use of the space, moving walls, or building out from scratch. Skip this step if you are taking over a previously-licensed salon space. See permits below.
10. **Verify staff credentials before opening.** Every hair stylist on your payroll must hold a valid Hair Stylist Journeyperson Certificate (or be a registered apprentice under supervision). Nail, esthetic, and lash staff do not require provincial credentials. See our Alberta cosmetology licensing guide.
11. **Obtain a sign permit before installing exterior signage.** Separate from the business licence. Fees depend on sign size and type. See permits below.

Realistic total timeline: 6 weeks minimum from "I want to open a salon" to "I am legally serving clients," assuming you are moving into a previously-licensed salon space. If you need development permits for a new build-out, add 4-8 weeks. Start everything as early as you can — lenders and landlords do not wait.

1. Municipal business licence (Calgary & Edmonton)

Every salon in Alberta operates under a municipal business licence. There is no province-wide salon licence — licensing is handled by each city. For a nail, hair, beauty, or barber shop, the category you need is **"Personal Service"**. Both Calgary and Edmonton use this exact label.

City of Calgary — Personal Service business licence

In Calgary, the 2026 Personal Service business licence breaks down like this:

- **Base fee:** $172 new / $131 renewal
- **Fire fee:** $72 new / $69 renewal
- **Planning fee:** $41 new / $0 renewal

- **Total: $285 new / $200 renewal** per year

Tattoo, microblading, and permanent makeup fall under a separate sub-category (**Personal Service — tattoo**) but the total fees are identical. If you operate as an independent chair operator — renting a chair in someone else's salon — Calgary offers a cheaper licence at $172 new / $131 renewal with no fire or planning fees, because the building inspection has already been done by the primary licensee.

Calgary also charges a **$785 non-resident business fee** if your salon is based outside Calgary but you operate within city limits (for example, mobile nail or beauty services). This is a one-time surcharge on top of your home city's licence.

Apply through Calgary's business licensing portal or in person at the Planning Services Centre (3rd floor, 800 Macleod Trail SE). Fire inspection is scheduled during the application process and takes roughly 5 business days. Expect your licence to be issued 5 to 15 business days after inspection passes.

City of Edmonton — Personal Service (Tier 3)

Edmonton uses a tiered fee structure under Bylaw 20002. Personal Service — which covers salons, barbers, nail techs, estheticians, and massage — is a **Tier 3** business category. Edmonton's fees for Tier 3 in the current schedule are:

- **1-year licence:** $265 new / $239 renewal
- **2-year licence:** $509 new / $457 renewal
- **Non-resident surcharge:** $479 for a 1-year non-resident licence, $957 for 2-year

Edmonton's 2-year option is worth considering for salons that want to lock in fees and avoid the annual renewal paperwork. On a per-year basis, 2-year works out to about $254/year new — slightly cheaper than paying annually, and $3 less than Calgary's annual fee.

Apply through the City of Edmonton business licence portal. Fire inspection is handled separately by Edmonton Fire Rescue Services; development compliance is reviewed by Planning and Development.

2. Alberta Health Services Personal Services Notification

This is the step most new salon owners either miss or misunderstand. Alberta Health Services does not issue a traditional paid "health permit" for personal service businesses. Instead, under the **Personal Services Regulation** (effective July 1, 2020), every salon must submit a **Personal Services Notification** to AHS before opening or before adding any new service.

Key facts:

- **Cost:** Free. No licence or permit fee.
- **Required for:** Hair, nails, aesthetics, facials, tanning, piercing, tattooing, microblading, eyelash extensions, waxing — essentially any service that enhances, preserves, or alters a client's appearance.
- **How to submit:** Online through the AHS Environmental Public Health case management portal at ephisahs.albertahealthservices.ca.
- **Before you open:** You can also request a voluntary plan review before construction starts — this prevents costly structural changes later.
- **Inspections:** Public health inspectors may visit to verify compliance with the *Personal Services Standards*, which cover cleaning, disinfection, sterilization, handwashing, ventilation, waste handling, and worker training.
- **Questions:** Call AHS Environmental Public Health at **1-833-476-4743** or visit ahs.ca/eph.

Even though there is no fee, treat this as a hard requirement. Operating a salon without notifying AHS puts you in violation of the *Public Health Act*, and an

inspector arriving unannounced can order you to stop offering services immediately. The paperwork takes under 30 minutes online.

> *If you offer any service that punctures skin or mucous membrane — piercing, tattoo, microblading — you also need written client-care instructions, sterilized critical equipment, and sharps containers, and AHS is likely to inspect your facility proactively.*

3. Trade name registration

If you plan to operate your salon under any name that isn't your exact legal name — for example, "Luxe Nail Studio" instead of "Thi Nguyen" — you need to register a trade name with Alberta Corporate Registry. If you operate as a corporation, incorporation handles this automatically. But for sole proprietors and partnerships, the trade name registration is a separate mandatory step.

Cost: $60 government fee. Registry agents (authorized private offices that process these for Alberta) typically charge an additional service fee of $40 to $75, so expect total cost of about $100 to $135.

Where: Any Alberta Registry Agent office. Walk-in service, typically completed same day.

Renewal: Every 5 years.

If you skip this step and your city business licence application uses a trade name, your licence will usually be rejected until the trade name is registered. Handle this first — it takes 15 minutes and unlocks everything downstream.

4. Hairstylist trade certification (hair salons only)

Here is the single biggest distinction in Alberta salon law: **hairstylist is a compulsory certified trade; nail tech and esthetician are not**.

In Alberta, anyone who cuts, colours, or styles hair for paying clients must hold a **Journeyperson Certificate in Hairstylist** issued by Alberta Apprenticeship and Industry Training, or be a **registered apprentice** working under the supervision of a certified journeyperson. This is not optional. A salon that lets an uncertified person cut hair is exposed to fines and enforcement action.

There are two paths to certification:

1. **Apprenticeship path.** Typically 1 to 2 years. Each 12-month period includes at least 1,450 hours of on-the-job training plus roughly 10 weeks of classroom instruction at an accredited school like M.C. College or NIWE Academy in Calgary.
2. **Trade Qualifier path.** For experienced stylists without a certificate. Requires 36 months and 4,350 hours of verifiable hairstylist work experience, plus passing both a theory exam and a practical exam.

What about nails, lashes, and esthetics? None of these are compulsory trades in Alberta. You do not need a provincial certificate to work on nails, perform facials, apply lash extensions, or wax clients. Your salon still needs a municipal business licence and AHS notification, and workers still need to follow the *Personal Services Standards* — but there is no government-issued personal certification for these roles. This is a real point of confusion for people moving from American states where nail technicians must hold a state licence. In Alberta, you do not.

What about barbers? Barber and hairstylist are closely linked in Alberta — the skills overlap significantly, and the certification framework is similar. Barbershop

owners should expect the same compulsory trade requirements for anyone cutting hair.

For current requirements, visit Tradesecrets — Hairstylist profile or call Alberta Apprenticeship directly.

5. GST number and WCB account

GST registration (CRA)

Once your salon's taxable revenue exceeds **$30,000 in any four consecutive calendar quarters**, you must register for a GST number with the Canada Revenue Agency. Before you hit that threshold you can register voluntarily — and many salon owners do, because it lets you claim input tax credits on the GST you pay on supplies, equipment, and rent. GST registration is free and can be done online in about 20 minutes.

WCB Alberta account

Anyone with employees in Alberta must have a Workers' Compensation Board account. Sole proprietors and partners are not automatically covered — you can opt in for personal coverage if you want. Registration is free; premiums are calculated annually as a percentage of your payroll based on your industry's injury risk rating. Salons are generally in a low-risk category, so expect low premium rates per $100 of payroll.

Independent contractors working as booth renters are a grey area. If you rent a chair to someone who sets their own hours and keeps their own tips, they may not be your employee — but document this carefully with a written agreement, and when in doubt, call WCB directly to confirm status.

6. Development, occupancy, and signage permits

These are the city-level permits that most salon owners forget until the landlord or inspector asks about them. They do not apply to every salon — but when they apply, they are the biggest and slowest part of the process.

Development permit

Required if you are changing the use of a commercial space (for example, converting a retail store into a salon), adding or moving walls, or building out a completely new space. In Calgary this is handled through Planning & Development Services. In Edmonton, through the Development Permit process at Development Services. Fees vary widely: from a few hundred dollars for minor work to several thousand for a full build-out. Timeline: 4 to 8 weeks is typical.

Building & occupancy permits

If construction involves structural work, plumbing, or electrical changes, you will also need building permits and a final occupancy permit before opening. The fire inspection tied to your business licence is a separate sign-off and does not replace occupancy review.

Sign permit

Both Calgary and Edmonton require a separate sign permit for most permanent exterior signs — not covered by your business licence. Fees depend on sign size, type (wall-mounted, freestanding, projecting), and whether it's illuminated. Apply through the city's sign permit process before installing any sign visible from the street.

> *Tip: if you are taking over an existing salon space that was previously licensed as a salon, you can usually skip the development permit entirely —*

> *the "use" has not changed. This is one of the fastest ways to open: find a former salon location and move in.*

Total cost at a glance (Calgary vs Edmonton 2026)

Here is what a brand-new small nail or beauty salon actually pays in licensing fees to open in 2026 — before any development work, signage, or insurance. These figures assume you are a sole proprietor operating under a trade name, with a rented commercial space that was previously licensed as a salon (so no development permit is needed).

Licence / Registration	Calgary	Edmonton
Trade name registration	$100–$135	$100–$135
AHS Personal Services Notification	Free	Free
Personal Service business licence (1 year, new)	$285	$265
GST number (CRA)	Free	Free
WCB account (if employees)	Free*	Free*
Minimum year-1 total	**~$385–$420**	**~$365–$400**
+ Sign permit (if applicable)	$100–$400	$100–$400
+ Development permit (if applicable)	$300–$3,000+	$300–$3,000+

* Registration is free. WCB premiums are calculated annually as a percentage of payroll.

Key takeaway: the **municipal business licence is by far the biggest recurring cost** at $265 to $285 per year. Everything else is either free, one-time, or renews

on a 5-year cycle. Calgary and Edmonton come in within $20 of each other — they are functionally identical from a cost standpoint. The real difference is in Edmonton's 2-year option, which modestly discounts the annual rate.

Timeline: when to start each step

Here is a realistic 6-week timeline to go from nothing to legally open, assuming you are moving into an existing salon space (no development permit). Double it if you are doing a full build-out.

- **Week -6 (six weeks before opening):** Register your trade name. Submit your AHS Personal Services Notification. If you're opening a hair salon, confirm every stylist's apprenticeship or journeyperson status.
- **Week -5:** Apply for your municipal business licence (Calgary or Edmonton). Schedule the fire inspection. Contact landlord about required tenant improvements.
- **Week -4:** Fire inspection happens. Apply for sign permit if you need exterior signage.
- **Week -3:** Business licence typically issued. Start hiring staff; have them complete onboarding and Personal Services Standards training.
- **Week -2:** Set up your point-of-sale and booking system. Register for GST if you expect to exceed the threshold in year one. Set up WCB if you have employees.
- **Week -1:** Final walkthroughs, equipment install, staff rehearsal, soft launch with friends and family.
- **Week 0:** Open for business. Inspectors may visit in the first 90 days.

If you are doing a full renovation, add 4 to 8 weeks for development and building permits at the very front of this timeline, and expect to start the licensing process after construction is done — the business licence application assumes a completed space.

Gotchas most salon owners miss

1. **The sign permit is separate.** Your business licence does not cover your exterior sign. If you install a big illuminated sign without a permit and a neighbour complains, the city will make you take it down.
2. **AHS notification is free — but mandatory.** Because there's no fee, people assume it's optional. It's not. Operating without notifying AHS is a violation of the *Public Health Act*.
3. **Fire inspection is scheduled, not on-demand.** In Calgary, fire inspection is part of the business licence application — you cannot skip it, and it adds 5+ business days to your timeline.
4. **Home-based or mobile services need a non-resident licence if you work across city lines.** Calgary's non-resident fee is $785. Edmonton's is $479.
5. **Your "nail tech" cannot legally cut hair for paying clients.** Even a quick bang trim or men's cut falls under the compulsory hairstylist trade. If you don't have a certified stylist, don't offer hair services at all.
6. **Booth renters are not automatically covered by your WCB.** If you have booth rental agreements, each renter may need their own licence and WCB coverage. Get this in writing.
7. **Your cosmetic products must comply with federal Health Canada regulations.** This includes full ingredient labelling. Cheap imports without English labels are a common AHS inspection finding.
8. **Insurance is not a licence — but your landlord will require it.** Most commercial landlords require $1M–$2M in general liability insurance before they'll hand over keys. Budget $500–$1,500/year for a salon-appropriate policy.

For Vietnamese nail salon owners

Alberta is one of the friendliest provinces in Canada for nail salon operators. Unlike California, Texas, or Florida — where nail technicians need an individual state licence — Alberta does not regulate nail tech or esthetician practice at the provincial level. You still need the business licence and AHS notification above, but there is no personal certificate required to do nails. If you are moving from the US, this is a significant reduction in paperwork compared to what you are used to.

Printable salon licence checklist

Here is the short version — a checklist you can print and check off as you go. Click the print button to generate a clean, one-page printable version.

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Alberta Salon Licensing Checklist (2026)

Calgary & Edmonton · Updated April 2026

BEFORE YOU START

- [ ] **Decide: sole proprietor, partnership, or corporation?**
  Affects whether you need a trade name registration.
- [ ] **Sign your commercial lease.**
  Your licence application needs a physical address.

- [ ] **Confirm the space was previously a licensed personal service business.**
  If not, plan for 4–8 extra weeks for development permit.

REQUIRED FOR EVERY SALON

- [ ] **Register trade name (if using one) — $60 + agent fee**
  Visit any Alberta Registry Agent. Same-day. Renew every 5 years.
- [ ] **Submit AHS Personal Services Notification — Free**
  Online at ephisahs.albertahealthservices.ca — or call 1-833-476-4743.
- [ ] **Apply for municipal business licence (Personal Service category)**
  Calgary: $285 new / $200 renewal. Edmonton: $265 new / $239 renewal (1 yr).
- [ ] **Pass fire inspection**
  Scheduled as part of business licence in Calgary; separate in Edmonton.
- [ ] **Purchase commercial general liability insurance — $500–$1,500/year**
  Most landlords require $1M–$2M coverage before handover.

REQUIRED IF APPLICABLE

- [ ] **Hair salons: Confirm every stylist has a Journeyperson Certificate or is a registered apprentice**
  Compulsory trade in Alberta.
- [ ] **Sign permit (if exterior signage) — $100–$400**
  Separate from business licence.
- [ ] **Development & building permits (if renovating) — $300+**
  Add 4–8 weeks to timeline.
- [ ] **WCB account (if employees) — Free to register**
  Premium is a percentage of payroll, billed annually.

- [ ] **GST registration (once revenue exceeds $30K/year) — Free**
  Can register voluntarily earlier to claim input tax credits.

BEFORE OPENING DAY

- [ ] **All cosmetic products labelled per Health Canada regulations**
  Includes ingredient lists and manufacturer info.
- [ ] **Disinfectants have a Drug Identification Number (DIN)**
  Issued by Health Canada.
- [ ] **Sharps container & written client-care procedures (if piercing/tattoo)**
  Required under Personal Services Standards.
- [ ] **Staff trained on hand hygiene, equipment reprocessing, glove use**
  AHS expectation under Personal Services Standards.
- [ ] **Booking system live & staff trained**
  Sicus Booking starts at $0/mo — sicusmedia.com

Not legal advice. Verify current fees with the City of Calgary (calgary.ca), City of Edmonton (edmonton.ca), and Alberta Health Services (ahs.ca/eph) before applying. Last updated April 2026.

Frequently asked questions

What licences do I need to open a salon in Alberta?

How much does a salon business licence cost in Alberta?

Do I need a provincial licence to do nails in Alberta?

Do hairstylists need a licence in Alberta?

What is the AHS Personal Services Notification and does it cost money?

How long does it take to get all my salon licences in Alberta?